

moderated by Academic Director Dr Alka Pande. On 8 August, Prof Anil Sooklal, High Commissioner of South Africa to India, delivered the keynote, framing the Global South not as a geography of deprivation but as a repository of cultural wealth. Tim Curtis, Director and Representative of UNESCO India, spoke on broadening the global concept of cultural heritage under the UNESCO Convention on Intangible Cultural Heritage.
Panel discussions drew together an extraordinary constellation of voices. Avni Sethi and Eva Malhotra examined museums as sites where objects resist and testify, using empathy as a curatorial method. Dr Ajit Pradhan, Alejandro Lepez, and Philippa Namutebi Kabali-Kagwa explored music as memory and migration. The following day, Dr Achal Pandya and Sari Sasaki discussed masks as symbols of sacred power, while Jagath Ravindra, Seema Kohli, and Juan Garibay turned to the feminine principle in art, gender, and material culture. The closing session on 9 August brought Dr Parul Pandya Dhar, Dr Agus Widyatmoko, and Dr Pornrat Damrung into a conversation on architecture as a living metaphor for the Ramayana across India, Indonesia, and Thailand.

Exhibitions as Living Dialogues

The Biennale unfolded like an atlas brought to life. The Bihar Museum and the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA) present **"Spiritual Crossing: Masks as Sacred Symbols, Ritual Objects and Theatrical Journey" (7th August – 31st December)**, a sweeping exploration of mask traditions from the continents of the Global South, Asia, Africa and Latin America. These regions have birthed, sustained and shared diverse spiritual practices tied to mask rituals, including shamanic traditions, mythological narratives, and ceremonial celebrations.



Since ancient times, masks have transcended boundaries between the self and the other, as well as between humans and gods. Rather than concealing, masks unravel invisible worlds through sensorial experiences: ceremonial, ritualistic, or performative. As unique, handcrafted objects, these masks embody both aesthetic and symbolic values. Dr Achal Pandya's curatorial insight, enriched by contemporary Indian artists such as Seema Kohli and Sachindranath Jha, reveals masks not as disguises but as portals—objects that connect the visible to the invisible, the self to the divine.

In the adjoining gallery, the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) unveils **"Our Worlds and Ourselves: Perspectives from Asia, Africa, and Latin America" (7th August – 31st December)**, tracing artistic responses to histories of colonisation and cultural marginalisation. Here, works are grouped into three interlinked sections—**The Self, The World and Reinventions**—each offering a way to see how artists have reclaimed identity, reimagined belonging, and forged solidarities beyond traditional global hierarchies. Highlighting creative practices from Asia, Africa and Latin America—regions that are often called the "global periphery", yet are rich with creative vitality, the exhibition traces journeys of resistance and renewal, shaped by histories of colonisation, cultural assertion and shared dreams of independence. It moves from personal reflection to global engagement to radical transformation, inviting viewers to see how artists have expanded what it means to belong, to remember and to create.

India shares a civilisational bond with Indonesia (the largest archipelagic country in the world with over 17,000 islands), spanning two millennia that is reflected in shared history, culture, language and values.

"Indonesia–India: A Bridge of Civilisations" (7th August – 21st September), the theme of the exhibition in the multipurpose hall celebrates the bridge of civilisations that continues to inspire cooperation across the Indo-Pacific, the shared richness and longstanding ties that were nurtured through maritime trade routes, temple architecture, integration of Sanskrit words into the Indonesian

